DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Would You Give Your Life for God?

Derech Hashem 4:4:5-6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraphs 5-6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 14 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The third point of Shema

The class continued the chapter on the misvah of Shema. So far the Ramhal has shown that Shema contains two points: Yihud Hashem, acknowledging that God is One, and Kabbalat Ol Malkhut Shamayim, accepting His kingship. Paragraph 5 adds a third: part of this misvah is that a person resolves to give up his life for the unity of God, and to accept suffering and even death for Kiddush Hashem. When he truly resolves this, it is considered as if he had done it, and it brings a great benefit to the whole world.

The Rabbi explained why this belongs to Yihud Hashem, picking up from the end of the previous class. If we really believe that there is no power or force outside Hakadosh Barukh Hu, and that everything in the universe is a manifestation of His presence, then that is true of ourselves as well. "We're existing by the strings of Hakadosh Barukh Hu." My life is His, and if He tells me to give it up, I give it up.

It is only our ego that makes this hard: my life, my human rights, I am not giving it up. When we see our own existence as nothing more than an expression of God's presence, we can say: this is what God wants, and I have no problem with it.

Being honest with yourself

We are rarely given the opportunity to do this in practice. But at the very least, when thinking of Yihud Hashem, a person should try to be honest and ask himself whether he would give up his life if he were put in that situation: a gun to his head to kill someone else, to commit adultery, or to bow down to an idol.

In passing the Rabbi noted that bowing to an actual idol is clearly avodah zarah, for which one must give up one's life. Converting to Islam would not require it, since it is not avodah zarah; Christianity is more of a question.

The resolution must be genuine. "You can't just say, okay, I'll jump in the fire." We cannot know what we would do on the day, but we can ask the question seriously now. A participant asked whether this should be said aloud. The Rabbi answered that it is not said; one thinks it during

Shema without any interruption: You are One, there is nothing else, even I do not exist in Your presence, and I am willing to give my life for You.

Light and darkness in balance

The Ramhal explains how this benefits the universe. God set the world at a particular spiritual level. By default it is mundane rather than holy, dark rather than light, and it allows a certain amount of evil to exist. Yet it must not be totally dark and impure, because then there would be no choice. There is a precise balance.

A participant asked whether before the Flood there was no balance. The Rabbi agreed that God had allowed things to reach that point, and that the promise after the Mabul was that He would not allow it again.

Within this level, extra light can come down at certain times. "Shabbat is a booster. Hagim is a booster." And every day the world needs fresh influence and light to raise it slightly above its mundane state. God made the arrival of this daily light dependent on the actions of human beings, and the action He chose to connect it to is mesirut nefesh, the willingness to give up one's life.

Someone who actually gives up his life brings down an enormous light. The Rabbi mentioned that the death of Rabbi Akiva was not quick but a long, drawn out process. But for the light needed each day, the Ramhal says, it is enough that we do it in our minds.

Why mesirut nefesh in particular?

The Rabbi asked the group why God made the daily light depend on this action in particular. One participant said it is a fundamental acceptance that Hashem is One. Another suggested that anything good we do brings down light; the Rabbi pointed out that this is not what the Ramhal says here. A third answer came close: in everything else a person does there may be some personal benefit, but here there is none.

The Rabbi brought the explanation of Rabbi Hayim Friedlander, one of the commentaries on Derech Hashem. The Gemara says that of the arrogant person, Hakadosh Barukh Hu says that He and that person cannot dwell together, because there is no room for Him. When a person is willing to nullify himself for Hakadosh Barukh Hu, God can finally dwell with him. The light that comes down is the Shekhinah, and "the more ego there is, the more of me there is, the less you can bring down that light." Willingness to give up one's life is the real demonstration that there is nothing apart from God, and that is how the light comes down.

Questions from the group

A participant compared this to those in another faith who seek to give their lives for God. The Rabbi asked whether that is not driven by personal benefit, the promised reward, and then turned the question on the group: if you would give up your life, why would you? Honestly, would some thought of reward be in the back of your mind? Anyone with no such thought, he said, is on a very high level.

Another participant asked what actually got better in the world after Rabbi Akiva gave his life. The Rabbi answered honestly that he could not say. According to what we have learned the

universe itself was elevated spiritually, but there is no way to measure that. He added that there is a known concept that the death of the righteous atones for their generation, as Hazal say about Miriam, and that this ties in with what was learned in Part 2 about one reason the righteous suffer: for the benefit of the people.

The Ramhal's summary (paragraph 6)

The Rabbi read paragraph 6 slowly, because it summarises the whole chapter so far. Shema contains three things:

1. Testimony and acknowledgement of God's unity.
2. Acceptance of the yoke of His kingship.
3. Giving up ourselves for Him.

And they have three consequences:

1. The strengthening of His unity over all creation, so that evil is subdued and good strengthened. If everyone recognised Yihud Hashem, there would be no need for evil any more, since evil exists so that we can choose to reveal God's oneness.
2. Hakadosh Barukh Hu becomes available to His creatures. This comes from making Him Melekh: "Elohim" is a distant God, but making Him King creates the relationship.
3. The daily illumination that the world needs is brought down.

Next time the class will turn to Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto LeOlam VaEd: what it is, where it came from, and why it is said quietly. It is not a verse in the Torah, unlike Shema and VeAhavta.

Summary

- The third point of Shema is the resolution to give up one's life for Kiddush Hashem; a genuine resolution counts as if it had been done.
- It follows from Yihud Hashem: if nothing exists apart from God, my life too is His, and only ego makes this hard.
- The world is balanced between darkness and light, and the daily light it needs depends on mesirut nefesh, even in thought.
- Following Rabbi Hayim Friedlander, self-nullification makes room for the Shekhinah, while ego pushes it away.
- Shema's three elements (unity, kingship, self-sacrifice) bring three results: evil subdued, a relationship with God, and light for the world.

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